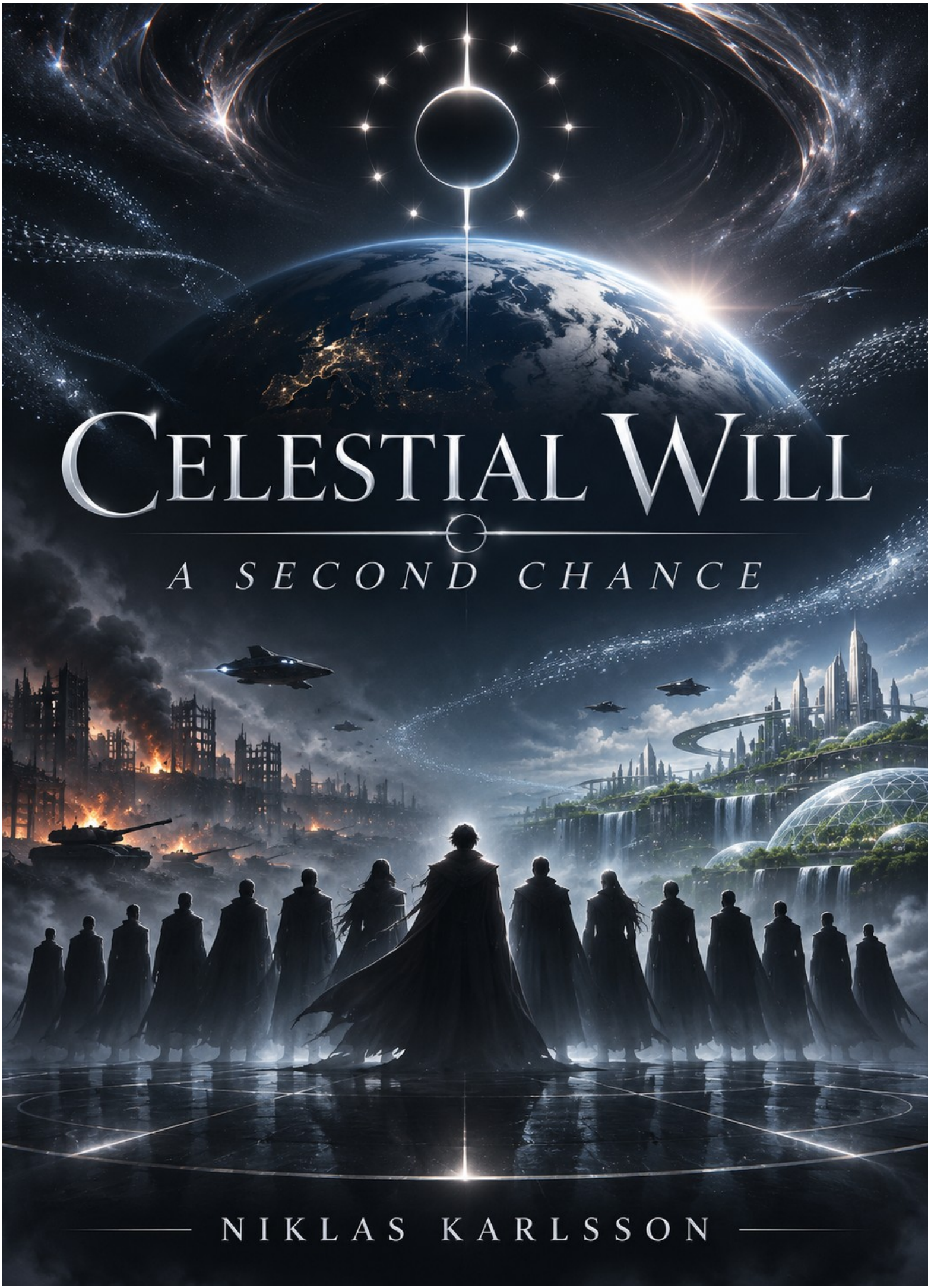

CELESTIAL WILL
A SECOND CHANCE
NIKLAS KARLSSON

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A Second Chance

Chapter One — Permission Granted

“Nanomancer 003 deploying. Enemy tank formation within target area. Requesting permission to deploy gravitational manipulation programs.”

The reply came without hesitation. “This is Command. Permission granted.”

Across a sunburned plain, an armored column advanced toward the last evacuation road out of the valley. Its crews had already driven the local defenders into retreat. They expected mines, perhaps a few desperate anti-tank teams. They did not expect the lead vehicle to sink into the asphalt as though its own weight had multiplied.

The suspension gave way first. Then the turret assembly buckled. Inside, warning alarms screamed, and the commander reached for a radio that had ceased to function. Beyond his viewport, the other tanks were suffering the same fate. One after another, they folded toward the ground under a force no weapon had visibly delivered.

“Formation immobilized,” 003 reported. “Increasing differential. Confirming crews remain alive.”

Steel groaned. Engines died. When the dust settled, twelve tanks sat crushed into shallow impressions in the road. The surrounding farmland was untouched.

“Enemy armor neutralized. No ammunition expended.”

Farther north, Nanomancer 013 watched the invaders’ field headquarters through a surveillance feed. Officers hurried between prefabricated buildings, carrying cases and encrypted terminals toward a waiting transport.

“Command, 013. Field command in sight. Proceeding with capture mission. Do we have extraction in place?”

“Specter team is standing by at Echo. Enemy command staff are preparing to relocate. You have eight minutes.”

“Understood.”

Before 013 could move, another voice entered the network.

“Nanomancer 008 here. Enemy aircraft on projected attack vector. Requesting permission to unleash Lightning Storm.”

“Authorized. Friendly aircraft are clearing your sector. Keep the effect above ground level. 013 is operating beneath their flight path.”

For a moment the sky remained clear. Then clouds gathered out of nowhere, rolling into one another with unnatural speed. Pilots approaching the valley saw their instruments flicker as lightning branched through the formation. The strikes were too precise to be weather. One aircraft fell; another broke away with both engines dead. The survivors turned back toward the horizon.

On the strategic channel, a voice cut through the reports.

“Nanomancer 002. Enemy tactical nuclear weapons confirmed. Deploying disarmament program.”

Six missiles were already rising from mobile launchers. Their engines burned for several seconds before guidance vanished and their trajectories changed. Far above the ground, swarms of nanomachines separated the weapons’ critical assemblies, rendering the payloads incapable of nuclear detonation. In aircraft holds and hardened bunkers, other warheads went inert before their crews could arm them.

Overwatch followed the results in disbelieving silence.

“002, confirm status,” Command said.

“Disarmament confirmed. Nuclear threat: zero percent.”

Someone in the command center let out a breath. Another laughed, once, from sheer disbelief.

“003 requesting permission to laugh,” came the familiar voice.

“Granted,” Command said.

The laughter had barely started when Nanomancer 001 entered the channel.

“001 requesting authorization to deploy Gravity Well against designated target.”

The atmosphere in Command changed.

“Negative pending assessment,” the commander replied. “The enemy is discussing surrender. Identify your target and immediate threat.”

“Enemy orbital weapons operations center. Extreme power buildup. Associated platform entering weapons-release configuration.”

New telemetry replaced the map. High above the planet, a structure emerged from shadow: an orbital bombardment platform carrying inert kinetic projectiles. Its control installation had ignored the surrender order. The projected impact points were clustered around the valley's evacuation routes and the cities beyond.

"Overwatch," Command said, "can we stop the release?"

"Not with conventional interception. They're too high, and the launch sequence is already active."

A second passed. Then another.

"001. Gravity Well deployment authorized. Restrict the effect to the designated military targets. Preserve the populated surface."

The response was almost a whisper.

"May the Creator forgive me for what I'm about to do."

The stars behind the orbital platform began to bend. At first it looked like a flaw in the observatory feed. Then the platform stretched toward a point of darkness. Metal, light, and the surrounding field of stars seemed to curve inward together. The control center vanished from the tactical map. The platform followed.

"Event horizon detected," Overwatch said. "Command, we're reading an artificial gravitational collapse."

"001, can you shut it down?"

"Compensating for temporal discrepancy," 001 replied. "Sixty seconds to core collapse. Get all friendlies to a safe distance. Remember: the aftershock affects a much larger area."

Orders flooded every channel. Specter lifted off with 013 and the captured command staff. 003 lent the transports acceleration no ordinary engines could produce. 008 steadied the sky along their route. The countdown continued, indifferent to the effort below.

At zero, the darkness disappeared.

There was no fireball. No sound. Instead, a distortion rippled through the fabric of space. Distant stars flickered out of position. Satellites jolted from stable orbits, and a pressure no one could hear passed over the upper atmosphere. Below it, millions of people looked up without knowing how close they had come to dying.

"001?" Command asked.

Only static answered.

“Nanomancer 001, report.”

At last, a faint signal resolved into words.

“001. Alive. Severe radiation damage. Nanomachine core intact. AI core intact. Conducting submolecular repairs. Estimated completion: seventy-eight hours.”

Command closed its eyes for a moment.

“Bring 001 home.”

Chapter Two — The Name in the Sky

Forty-eight hours later, the image was playing on every news channel: a distant installation folding into a darkness that lasted less than a minute.

“What we’re watching,” the anchor said, “is an unknown aggressor destroying a previously unknown orbital facility. The invading forces have ceased hostilities. Their armies have withdrawn. Why?”

The retired general beside her watched the footage without blinking.

“Because they encountered something they couldn’t fight.”

“What did they encounter?”

“That,” he said, “is the question that should frighten us.”

The studio monitors went black.

So did every other screen on Earth.

Televisions, phones, public displays, and military terminals showed the same symbol: a circle surrounded by thirteen points of light. An even, synthetic voice filled the silence.

“This was the work of Celestial Will. We are an unaffiliated organization. As long as we operate, weaponized conflicts will not be tolerated. Test us, and you will find out why you should not.”

Seventeen seconds later, the world’s broadcasts resumed exactly where they had stopped.

In government offices, people demanded explanations no one could provide. At the United Nations, diplomats argued over whether Celestial Will had declared itself protector, occupier, or judge of humanity. It had no treaty, no recognized territory, and no visible chain of command. Yet the invasion had ended, and no government could plausibly claim to have made it happen.

In Celestial Will's own command center, the argument was interrupted by a field report.

"003 reporting. Armed force attacking a civilian convoy. Requesting permission to assist in its defense."

"Authorized. Protect the civilians. End the attack with the minimum necessary force."

Fourteen vehicles were trapped on a narrow highway. The attackers had six armored vehicles, infantry, and the advantage of position. A bus full of families stood in the path of a gun turret already turning toward it.

The turret stopped.

The armored vehicle rose from the road, hanging above its own shadow. Rifles slipped from soldiers' hands. Grenades opened harmlessly; ammunition fell apart into components that drifted to the ground. Across the highway, weapons and vehicles became useless at the same instant.

"This is Celestial Will," 003 announced over every radio. "Cease hostilities and surrender."

The surrender was immediate.

The convoy carried political dissidents attempting to flee their government. Intercepted orders told the rest of the story: a regional general had been instructed to prevent the crossing by force. A defense minister then ordered a false account of the engagement. The head of government discussed eliminating witnesses before the truth could spread.

"Nanocore 067 to Command. Units 068 and 069 are in position to seize the responsible officials. Advise. Do we proceed?"

"Hold until the evidence is verified."

Nanocore 089 routed another intercepted conversation to Command. In it, the head of government sought foreign assistance in concealing the convoy attack. The foreign official refused, but not before the speaker confirmed knowledge of the order.

“Authentication complete,” Strategic Intelligence reported. “Orders originated at the highest level of government.”

“067, 068, 069,” Command said. “Apprehension authorized. Protect bystanders. Preserve all records. No unnecessary injuries.”

Three senior officials vanished from positions they had believed secure. Armed guards found their weapons in pieces. Within minutes, Celestial Will held the head of government, the defense minister, and a senior official involved in the operation.

Stopping a battle had been extraordinary. Seizing the leaders who ordered it was something else entirely.

The next global announcement came with court records, authenticated communications, witness statements, and a judgment. Celestial Will declared the three officials guilty of war crimes and crimes against humanity. It announced death sentences, subject to a thirty-day period for objections and review.

The reaction was fierce. International lawyers noted that the International Criminal Court did not impose the death penalty, and that Celestial Will had no recognized authority to speak in its name. Survivors demanded accountability. Human-rights organizations demanded independent judges and genuine appeals. Governments demanded the return of the prisoners, sometimes in the same breath as they condemned the original attack.

From a recovery chamber, 001 listened to the arguments.

“If someone demonstrates an error,” 001 told Command, “we must be prepared to reverse the judgment. Otherwise the review is theater.”

“Agreed,” Command replied. “The review will be genuine.”

But the public had heard another message beneath the legal dispute. A head of government had been arrested in his own residence, and no army had been able to prevent it.

The rules of power were changing.

Chapter Three — Operation Peace

The next broadcast was not intended for humanity at large.

“This is Command AI Core. Operation Peace is commencing. All operatives within conflict areas are to suppress hostilities at full capability. Every Nanomancer is to deploy according to mission briefing, including personnel in deep cover.”

Acknowledgments arrived from every continent.

“024 reporting. Deep cover terminated.”

“041 reporting. Weapons-production systems secured.”

“056 reporting. Naval command infiltrated. Targeting systems under control.”

“072 reporting. Insurgent leadership located.”

There were ninety-nine combat Nanomancers, but their reach extended through networks of autonomous microscopic machines and the artificial intelligences directing them. Some had spent years living beneath ordinary names, working as technicians, officers, analysts, and soldiers. Now they stood up in familiar rooms and revealed what they were.

On an aircraft carrier, a communications officer informed his admiral that every weapon aboard the fleet had been disabled. In a command bunker, a trusted intelligence analyst dismantled a general’s sidearm before he could draw it. On a ruined front line, artillery shells halted in the air above the trenches. Both armies watched them hang there, neither side certain whether to cheer or pray.

War stopped in fragments. An artillery exchange here. A strike mission there. A naval confrontation elsewhere. Commanders discovered that an order to fire no longer guaranteed anything would happen.

Within hours, sustained military operations had become impossible wherever Celestial Will chose to intervene.

“Command,” 013 said, “some combatants are switching to improvised weapons.”

“Stop hostile actions regardless of the weapon involved.”

“And if we leave?” 002 asked.

No one answered at once. The Nanomancers could disarm soldiers, but they could not dissolve a border dispute, erase a massacre from living memory, or persuade enemies to forgive each other.

“We give them the room to negotiate,” Command said at last. “What they do with that room is their responsibility.”

Then the Medical Division received its orders.

“Nanomancers 100 through 167, report for duty.”

Sixty-eight voices answered. They went to overwhelmed hospitals and temporary clinics, refugee camps and cities that had spent years without reliable care. Their nanomachines stopped internal bleeding, rebuilt tissue, neutralized infections, and restored organ function. What conventional medicine called irreversible became, sometimes within hours, a matter of careful repair.

At a field hospital, a surgeon watched a heart monitor flatten. He had already worked through two nights and knew the patient could not survive another minute without circulation.

A woman in a grey uniform stepped beside him.

“May I assist?” she asked.

The surgeon stared at her. “His heart has stopped.”

“I know.”

Silver particles moved from her hand into the wound. A pulse appeared on the monitor. Then another. Color returned slowly to the patient’s face.

“What are you?” the surgeon whispered.

“Nanomancer 101,” she said. She looked toward the crowded beds. “A doctor. And we have more patients.”

Requests soon arrived from far beyond the battlefields. Hospitals asked for help with congenital disorders, failing organs, degenerative illnesses, and conditions that had defeated generations of researchers.

“Human lives are worth protecting from war,” Medical Command’s Nanomancer 100 told the central AI. “Are they worth protecting from everything else?”

The question remained unanswered when a new set of deployment orders appeared.

Chapter Four — The Work of Restoration

“Operation Restoration is authorized,” Command AI announced. “Terraforming and Engineering Nanomancers 168 through 300 are to deploy to the areas under highest humanitarian strain. Restore infrastructure. Secure food, water, and shelter. These are your priorities.”

One hundred and thirty-three operatives replied.

In the ruins of one city, a grey-clad figure walked down a street that no longer deserved the name. The apartment blocks had collapsed years before. Water pipes had become trenches for sewage. Children played among concrete slabs because they had never seen the neighborhood intact.

The figure raised one hand.

Dust lifted from the rubble. Concrete separated into usable material; twisted steel flowed into new supports. Foundations strengthened. Walls climbed into place, floor by floor, as if someone were playing the city’s destruction in reverse—but the rebuilt homes had safer stairwells, better insulation, and clean water running through their walls.

An old man watched the outline of his former building return.

“My wife and I lived on the fourth floor,” he told Nanomancer 172.

“Would you like the original floor plan?”

The old man stared. “You can do that?”

“I can. But I recommend a lift this time.”

In refugee settlements, shelter replaced canvas and scrap metal. Water treatment plants appeared beside reservoirs. Electrical grids took shape beneath new roads. Elsewhere, 197 rebuilt damaged soil while 184 restored the water cycle that would keep it fertile. Farmers knelt to touch dark earth where the wind had carried away dust for years.

And everywhere the same questions followed the miracles. Who owned a reconstructed building? Who decided where water flowed? Could a community maintain a machine it barely understood? Would Celestial Will remain to settle disputes over what it had made?

“We can create the infrastructure,” 300 reported. “But if we govern every decision about it, restoration becomes occupation.”

“Then we don't govern it,” Command answered. “Transfer control to the communities. Make the systems maintainable. Leave people capable of sustaining what we build.”

The United Nations requested a meeting. Governments sought assurances, oversight, access to the technology, and recognition that restored territories remained their own. Before any formal agreement could be announced, every screen on Earth went dark once more.

The circle and its thirteen lights appeared.

“This is Celestial Will. Operation Restoration is concluded. As long as humanity does not resume hostilities, we will no longer interfere again. Humanity has been given a second chance. Do not squander this opportunity.”

The message ended.

There was no victory parade, no anthem, no demand for tribute. The Nanomancers simply withdrew. Roads remained. Hospitals remained. Water flowed and harvests grew. So did the old arguments about land, history, power, and blame.

A year passed.

People still protested, voted, struggled, bargained, and fought with words. Some borders remained unsettled. Political prisoners did not all walk free. No one mistook the world for a paradise. But the armies did not return to battle. Children crossed streets that had once been front lines. A generation of refugees began to unpack belongings they had kept ready to carry away.

On the anniversary of the withdrawal, a news anchor asked the retired general whether Celestial Will was truly gone.

“We don't know,” he said. “But perhaps we've been asking the wrong question.”

“What should we ask?”

“Whether we can learn to live as though nobody is waiting to stop us.”

Chapter Five — Thirteen in the Dark

The chamber had no windows.

Thirteen silhouettes sat around a circular table. Between them floated a small blue Earth, its cloud systems turning in silence. Their seats bore numbers instead of names.

The Third faced the First.

“It seems your predictions were accurate,” the Third said. “There was no need for Project Purge.”

“Not yet,” the First replied.

“Even if humanity behaves now, we must maintain our technological advantage. If they fall back into their old patterns, we must be able to purge the population and repopulate the planet. You understand this?”

“Perfectly.”

“Then we agree.”

“On retaining our advantage,” said the First. “Not on assuming Purge will become necessary.”

The Fourth stirred in the darkness. “The distinction is academic. The contingency exists because humanity may fail.”

“And it remains a contingency,” the First said. “Not a destination.”

The Eleventh summoned a second image: hidden genetic archives, artificial gestation chambers, educational systems designed to raise children who would never know the civilization that preceded them. Everything required to begin again stood ready beneath layers of secrecy.

“No inherited borders,” the Eleventh said. “No ancestral feuds. We could give the next humanity a cleaner beginning.”

“And what would keep those children from creating new borders?” the Seventh asked. “Or fighting over resources we cannot predict?”

The Eleventh said nothing.

“Nothing,” answered the First. “There is no guarantee.”

The Third leaned back. “One year of peace cannot cancel thousands of years of war.”

“Nor did I claim it would. I predicted that removing the immediate causes of collapse and offering a viable alternative might change humanity’s course. We now have evidence that it can.”

“Or evidence that it fears us.”

“Perhaps,” said the First. “That is what we are waiting to discover.”

The Thirteenth, silent until now, looked at the little planet.

“Can a people truly choose peace while an overwhelming force stands ready to punish war?”

The question hung in the chamber.

“Obedience is not peace,” the First said finally. “Fear is not wisdom. If humanity learns to resolve its disputes without thinking of us, then our work will have achieved something beyond a ceasefire.”

The Second changed the projection. New Nanocore architectures spun above the table, more capable than those carried by the original three hundred operatives. Entire manufacturing systems could be controlled by a single intelligence. The gap between Celestial Will and the human civilization below was widening.

“Research continues,” the Second reported. “Our next generation will exceed the original Nanomancer designs by a substantial margin.”

“Good,” the Third said. “It must never narrow.”

The First stood.

“Accelerate development. Keep Project Purge dormant. Maintain every safeguard. If we ever activate it, it will mean that we have failed on a scale no one here should mistake for victory.”

One by one, the figures left the chamber. At last only the First remained, watching Earth turn above the empty table.

A voice spoke from the dark. The Command AI Core, no longer addressing armies or directing reconstruction, sounded almost curious.

“First. Your projections for sustainable human peace have changed.”

“They have.”

“In which direction?”

“For the better.”

“And Project Purge?”

“Keep it ready.”

The First looked at the blue planet once more.

“I hope it becomes the most expensive thing we ever build and never use.”

Far below, morning spread across cities rebuilt by invisible hands. People woke, argued, worked, fell in love, elected leaders, and planned futures they could finally imagine reaching. None of them knew about the thirteen figures in the dark—or the sleeping machinery that could replace them.

For now, that ignorance was part of their second chance.

CELESTIAL WILL

A SECOND CHANCE

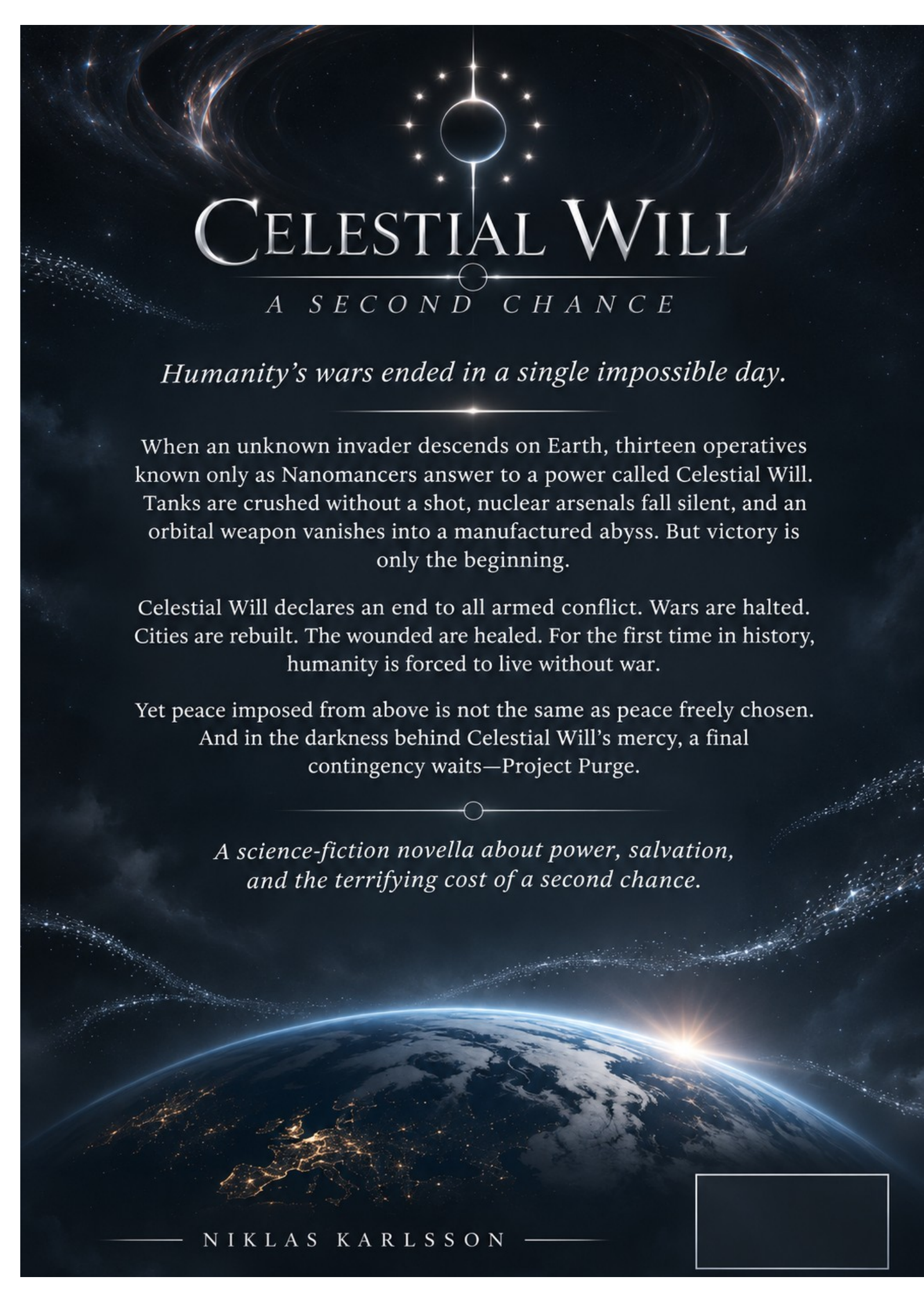
Humanity's wars ended in a single impossible day.

When an unknown invader descends on Earth, thirteen operatives known only as Nanomancers answer to a power called Celestial Will. Tanks are crushed without a shot, nuclear arsenals fall silent, and an orbital weapon vanishes into a manufactured abyss. But victory is only the beginning.

Celestial Will declares an end to all armed conflict. Wars are halted. Cities are rebuilt. The wounded are healed. For the first time in history, humanity is forced to live without war.

Yet peace imposed from above is not the same as peace freely chosen. And in the darkness behind Celestial Will's mercy, a final contingency waits—Project Purge.

A science-fiction novella about power, salvation, and the terrifying cost of a second chance.



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